



The "X" In Office 2007 What's with the "x"?

The file formats for Office 2007 will use XML and ZIP. The Office 2007 suite files will have default file extensions with "x" after their "old" file extensions—so, for example, .doc and .xls become .docx and .xlsx.

Why is XML used in Office?

Using XML, documents consisting of structured information as content will have some indication of what role that content will perform. XML-based file formats will aid in smooth data interoperability, data management and security, recovery of data, and, of course, reduced file sizes.

How are these different?

Office XML documents will be backwards-compatible with previous versions of the suite. Office XML file formats are ZIP-compressed as a ZIP container, which results in reduced file sizes and improved data recovery with corrupted files. Since the Office XML file formats are platform-independent, any non-Microsoft application such as XML-Broker can be used to process them.

Where does "m" fit into this?

Office 2007 documents saved in Office XML format will not contain any type of code or automation files, which can therefore never be unexpectedly executed. Documents containing VBA Projects, embedded OLE objects, and other binary files can be saved as macro-enabled files, as in .docm and .xlsm. The container package can be inspected for malicious code without even running an Office application.

Who will benefit?

Users, developers, IT professionals and organisations. The openness of Office XML formats aids in third-party application development, and in the creation of task-oriented documents—like reports, spreadsheets or forms with specifications, instructions, procedures or style guides.

When will we see Office 2007?

The last we heard, Microsoft planned a January 2007 release. You can try the Beta 2 from this month's *Digit* DVD.

Smaller players obviously stand to lose: "By combining MSN and Yahoo! contacts, it will be much more convenient to talk with friends on those networks, rather than on AIM or Google Talk," avers Teney Takahashi, senior market analyst at the Radicati Group. "We expect this will drive customers away from more isolated IM services."

ADOBE FLEXES MUSCLES

Flex 2 Launched

Adobe has launched the next version of Flex, which gives Flash developers a platform to develop more complex applications—enterprise-level, even—with much greater ease than before.

Dave Gruber, Product Marketing Manager for Adobe Systems, was in India in mid-July to promote the launch, stating that India was a key market for Flex, thanks to its large population of Java developers. Flex gives Java developers the ability to build Flash-based front-ends for their existing (and upcoming) Java applications.

Since taking over Macromedia, Adobe has rebuilt the Flash Player almost from scratch, adding a Just-In-Time compiler that will run SWF files faster and more efficiently than before. It will also support data streams that will come from Flex applications, and yet have a smaller memory footprint than previous versions of Flash Player.

We're immensely glad that something worthwhile is being done with Flash for a change—this much-abused technology is finally being revamped to do more useful things than annoy the hell out of Internet visitors. One of the demo programs we saw was a full-fledged e-mail client, and the possibilities seem quite promising. Unfortunately, the idiots who build 3 MB Flash

presentations and call it their Web sites will probably never learn, but with Flex, the file will only be 2 MB.

In other news, Gruber also confirmed what we were long expecting anyway—the slow fading away of the Macromedia brand. Every new version of Macromedia software will now carry the Adobe tag.

REVOLUTIONARY

Linking The Physical And Digital Worlds

"Invent", goes HP's tagline, or tag-word. But HP is, as we know, not very well known for its inventions... however, here's something that could justify the tagline: researchers at HP recently created an extremely small wireless microchip, called the Memory Spot, which can be used to *affix digital content to physical objects*. This is revolutionary, if not in concept, at least in the way it can be implemented. For example, the chip could be pinned to a photo print, and provide access to the original digital photo!

The Memory Spot measures just 2 mm by 4 mm, is based on CMOS technology, and has a processor, memory, and an antenna.

The chip is self-contained: it is powered by the devices that read and write the data from and to it. These read/write devices power up the chip as they pass over it: the concept here is "inductive coupling," which transfers energy from one circuit to another by means of a shared electromagnetic field.

The readers could be incorporated into cell phones, PDAs, cameras, printers, etc. They could transfer the data on the Memory Spot to a display screen or elsewhere.

Current, working prototypes of the Memory Spot can hold from 32 to 500 KB. The data transfer rate is 10 Mbps—about 10 times faster than Bluetooth. The device operates at 2.45 GHz.

Howard Taub, VP and associate director of Hewlett-Packard Laboratories, said HP's aim was to make potential partners aware of the technology, so they can discuss how it might be further developed and deployed. He said software development kits (SDKs) for developing Memory Spot-related applications will be made available to partners.

"We can put (the chip) literally anywhere," Taub said in a demonstration in San Francisco. "I can embed it on a piece of paper and it will be unobtrusive." Taub showed how the chip could be used to attach an audio file of a physician reading a prescription to a pill bottle.

Taub has called the chip "RFID on steroids." The Memory Spot is indeed something like RFID, but there are several differences—including size, range, data transfer speed, security, and so on.

Potential applications include storing medical records on a patient's wristband; providing audio-visual supplements to postcards and photos; adding security to identity cards and passports; and tagging information to printed documents. One could think of more uses, of course.

The invention heralds a new era in the bridging of the physical and digital worlds: "The Memory Spot chip frees digital content from the electronic world of the PC and the Internet and arranges it all around us in our physical world," said Ed McDonnell, Memory Spot project manager, HP Labs.

An endnote: amidst the furore over the Bush administration's efforts to gain more access to personal information—part of its campaign against terrorism—there are worries about the US government abusing the technology. ■